

Diabetes: A Short Guide

A simple overview of what diabetes is, its main types, warning signs, prevention, and management.

Key idea: Diabetes is a long-term condition in which blood glucose (blood sugar) becomes too high because the body does not make enough insulin or cannot use insulin effectively.

How insulin works

Glucose from food is an important source of energy. Insulin, a hormone made by the pancreas, helps glucose move from the blood into the body's cells. When insulin is missing or does not work properly, glucose builds up in the bloodstream.

Main types of diabetes

Type 1

The immune system destroys insulin-producing cells. The body makes little or no insulin, so daily insulin treatment is required.

Type 2

The body becomes resistant to insulin or cannot make enough. It is the most common type and may develop gradually.

Gestational diabetes

This develops during pregnancy. It usually improves after delivery, but it increases the parent's and child's future risk of type 2 diabetes.

Common symptoms

- Frequent urination
- Increased thirst or hunger
- Unexplained weight loss
- Tiredness or weakness
- Blurred vision
- Slow-healing sores or frequent infections

Important: Type 2 diabetes may cause few or no noticeable symptoms. A blood test is needed for diagnosis.

Risk, diagnosis, and management

Healthy habits help, but diabetes is not caused by a single food or personal failure.

Risk factors for type 2 diabetes

Health and lifestyle	Background and history
Physical inactivity, overweight, high blood pressure, abnormal cholesterol levels, or prediabetes.	Family history, increasing age, or a history of gestational diabetes. Risk can vary among populations.

Diagnosis

A health professional may use blood tests such as an A1C test, fasting plasma glucose test, or oral glucose tolerance test. Test choice and interpretation depend on symptoms, age, pregnancy, medicines, and medical history.

Management

Monitor Check blood glucose as advised and attend regular appointments.	Medicines Use insulin or other prescribed medicines exactly as directed.
Daily habits Choose balanced meals, stay active, sleep well, and avoid smoking.	Prevent complications Keep up with eye, kidney, foot, blood pressure, and cholesterol checks.

Why control matters

Over time, high blood glucose can damage the heart, blood vessels, eyes, kidneys, and nerves. Good diabetes care can greatly reduce the risk of these complications.

Seek urgent medical help

Get immediate help for severe vomiting, trouble breathing, confusion, fainting, or very high or very low blood glucose that does not improve. These can be signs of a medical emergency.

Sources

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC): Diabetes Basics and Symptoms of Diabetes. National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases (NIDDK): What Is Diabetes? and Diabetes Tests and Diagnosis. World Health Organization (WHO): Diabetes Fact Sheet. Accessed July 2026.

Educational note: This guide provides general information and does not replace advice, diagnosis, or treatment from a qualified health professional.